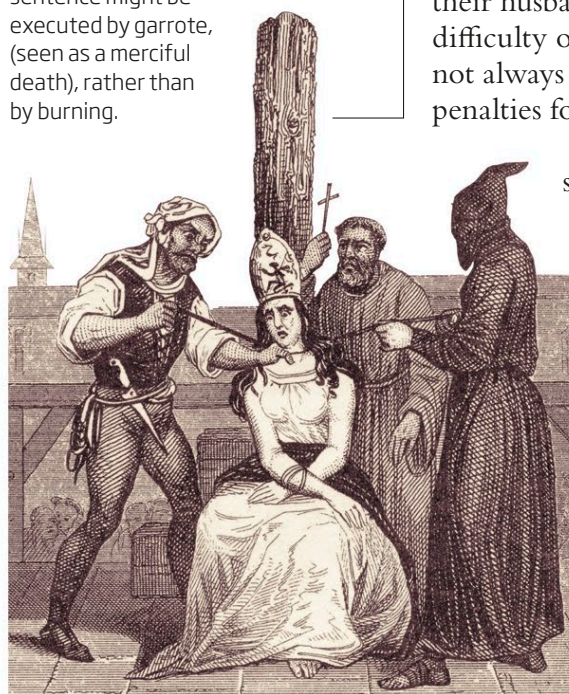


WARRIORS, WIVES, AND widowhood

THE SPANISH RECONQUISTA

▼ **Converso woman**

During the Spanish Inquisition, the civil tribunals used different execution methods for false converts. A woman who truly converted to Catholicism after receiving her death sentence might be executed by garrote, (seen as a merciful death), rather than by burning.



During the early 8th century, Muslim Arabs invaded the Iberian Peninsula (Spain) from North Africa, establishing a territory called Al-Andalus. It became one of the most cosmopolitan and culturally advanced states in Europe, with freedom to practice their religions generally extended to Christians and Jews. Meanwhile, Christian kingdoms that survived in the north (mainly León, Castile, Navarre, Aragon, and Portugal) fought to regain control in a process that lasted nearly eight centuries: the Reconquista.

The near-constant warfare of the Reconquista made widowhood common. Women who wished to remarry faced particular challenges, such as being sure their husbands had actually died (given the difficulty of communication then, this was not always easy). Some states had heavy penalties for bigamy—a law introduced in the kingdom of Castile in 1241 stated that if a woman remarried while her first husband still lived, she and her new husband could both be sold into serfdom (tied to landowners as peasants). By the 15th century, after years of fighting, most of the Iberian Peninsula was once again in Christian hands. The final surviving Muslim state was the Emirate of Granada, in what is now southern Spain. Queen Isabella I of Castile and her husband Ferdinand II of Aragon—joint rulers with equal

powers—were determined to conquer it and bring all of Spain under Christian rule. In 1492, following a decade of hard fighting, Granada finally surrendered. The Reconquista laid the foundations for Spain to become

Europe's most influential power in the 16th century, but the process was a long and bloody one, and left behind a legacy of religious intolerance and violence.

**Fewer than
1%
of the people tried
by the Spanish
Inquisition
were executed**

The Inquisition

Isabella and Ferdinand initially agreed to grant freedom of religion to the Jews and Muslims who lived in Granada, but soon went back on their promise and demanded compulsory

conversion to Catholicism. In March 1492, the monarchs put out an edict expelling all practicing Jews, and in 1501, Muslims were ordered to convert or leave. Tens of thousands of people left Granada and resettled elsewhere in Europe, North Africa, and the Americas.

Just as they did in Castile and Aragon, Jews and Muslims who had converted—known as *conversos* and *moriscos*, respectively—still faced persecution, as Ferdinand and Isabella sent out Inquisitors to identify heretics. *Morisco* women were made to give up their traditional language and dress, and *converso* women were given special attention by the Holy Inquisitors, who suspected them of carrying on customs such as observing the Sabbath or making kosher food. Some were even thought to have washed holy water off of their babies after baptism in order to de-Christianize them. Along with other suspected heretics, such women were put on trial and, if found guilty, were burned at the stake.